

DINNER · POPPY'S KITCHEN

Spinach & Cottage Cheese Baked Pasta

A lazy lasagna: creamy, cheesy, high-protein baked pasta with spinach hiding in plain sight.

4, plus a lunch	50 min
SERVES	START TO TABLE
15 min	35 min
PREP	COOK

Weeknight bake

🛒 What you need

FROM THE STORE

- ☐ **1 lb** Pasta (rotini or penne)
- ☐ **1 jar** Rao's marinara
- ☐ **2 cups** Cottage cheese
- ☐ **5 oz** Baby spinach, chopped
- ☐ **1** Egg
- ☐ **2 cups** Tillamook mozzarella, shredded
- ☐ **½ cup** Grated parmesan
- ☐ **3 cloves** Garlic, minced

FROM THE PANTRY

- ☐ **1 Tbsp** Olive oil
- ☐ **1 tsp** Italian seasoning
- ☐ Salt and pepper

⚡ **First:** Oven to 400°F and the pasta water on.

GEAR

Big pot · 9×13 dish · Big bowl

🔥 Let's cook

1. Heat the oven to 400°F. Boil the pasta 2 minutes less than the box says. Drain. ⏱️ 10 min
2. While it boils, cook the garlic in the oil 30 seconds, add the spinach and stir until wilted. ⏱️ 2 min
3. In a big bowl mix the cottage cheese, egg, half the parmesan, Italian seasoning, salt and pepper. 🧒 Kids can do this
4. Fold in the spinach, the pasta, 2 cups marinara and 1 cup mozzarella. 🧒 Kids can do this
5. Spread in a 9×13. Spoon the rest of the sauce on top, then the last mozzarella and parmesan. 🧒 Kids can do this
6. Bake 20 minutes until bubbly; broil 2 minutes for brown spots. Rest 5 minutes. ⏱️ 22 min

👨‍🍳 CHEF'S SECRET

Undercook the pasta by 2 minutes. It finishes in the oven soaking up sauce, so it ends up just right instead of mushy.



DINNER · FLIP SIDE

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👩‍🍳 Kitchen crew: kid jobs

- [ ] Crack the egg into the cottage cheese and stir
- [ ] Tear up the spinach
- [ ] Spread it in the dish and add the cheese on top
- [ ] Set out parmesan for the table

Knives, the stove and the oven: a grown-up stays right there. Steps marked 🧒 **Kids can do this** on the front are theirs to own.

⏰ MAKE IT AHEAD

Assemble a day ahead (fridge, covered); bake 30 minutes.

🥡 LEFTOVERS

Reheats better than it starts. Perfect lunch.

🔁 SWAP IT

- Barilla Protein+ pasta for even more protein
- Ricotta instead of cottage cheese
- Add browned Italian sausage

🍽️ SERVE IT WITH

Spring mix with Italian dressing, garlic toast

⏱️ Game plan: everything lands at once

50 min out	Oven to 400°F. Pasta water on to boil.
40 min	Pasta in. Wilt the spinach with garlic. Kids mix the cheese filling.
32 min	Drain. Kids fold it all together and fill the 9×13.
27 min	Into the oven for 20 min, then 2 min under the broiler.
5 min	Rest so it slices clean.
Dinner	Serve with a salad or garlic toast.

Done cooking? Tell Poppy how it went.

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